

Protesters Challenge Trump's Proposed Arch Near Washington Landmarks

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Dozens of people gathered at Memorial Circle in Washington, D.C., on Thursday, October 1, 2026, to protest a large arch proposed by President Donald Trump. The planned structure would stand 250 feet tall in a traffic circle on the bridge connecting the National Mall to Arlington National Cemetery.

Veterans, retirees and lawmakers attended the protest. Speakers questioned the arch's size, cost and location, as well as its lack of **congressional approval**. They stood beside a model made from a tarp, which they said was much smaller than the proposed monument.

Jon Gundersen, a retired Army veteran and former Foreign Service officer, traveled from South Carolina to attend. He is among the Vietnam War veterans suing the **administration** over the project. Public Citizen, a group leading that lawsuit, helped organize the protest.

Several speakers said veterans and their families should have more input into the plans. Senator Tammy Duckworth and other opponents argued that improving services for veterans would be a better way to honor them.

The White House has offered a different view. It told NPR that the arch would improve visits to the cemetery and serve as a reminder of American heroes' sacrifices.

The proposal is still moving through federal approval steps. **Administration** officials told **historic preservation** groups at a Tuesday meeting that they planned to continue with the original arch proposal. The National Capital Planning Commission is widely expected to consider it at its meeting in early November.

A separate review concerning nearby protected landmarks ended early in the last week of September. The Advisory Council on **Historic Preservation** said it would send recommendations directly to Interior Secretary Doug Burgum by October 7. Charles Birnbaum of The Cultural Landscape Foundation criticized the decision to end discussions after only two meetings.

Some protesters hope Congress will block **federal funding** for the arch. An attempt by Democrats to do so was blocked by a Republican senator earlier that week. November's **midterm elections** could change which party holds power in Congress, potentially affecting the project starting in January. For now, the lawsuit continues and final federal approval remains **pending**.

Word Treasure

congressional approval -- Permission or agreement from Congress.

administration -- The president and the officials working under the president.

historic preservation -- Protecting places valued for their history.

federal funding -- Money supplied by the national government.

midterm elections -- Elections held halfway through a president's term that can change which party controls Congress.

pending -- Awaiting a decision or completion.

Break it down

The opening establishes the protest's date and location and describes the proposed arch's height and site.

The article identifies participants, explains their objections and introduces the veterans' lawsuit. It contrasts opponents' preference for improved veteran services with the White House's stated reasons for the arch.

It outlines the federal approval process and the early end of a separate historic preservation review.

The ending explains the funding dispute, possible election effects and the project's unresolved status.

Why it matters

The dispute connects a proposed monument with veterans' input, public spending, congressional authority and protection of nearby landmarks. Ongoing legal and federal review processes leave the project's future undecided.

Test what you remember

1. When did the protest at Memorial Circle take place?

- ☐ (A) The last week of September
- ☐ (B) October 7, 2026
- ☐ (C) Early November
- ☐ (D) Thursday, October 1, 2026

2. How is Jon Gundersen involved in the dispute?

- ☐ (A) He is among the Vietnam War veterans suing the administration over the project.
- ☐ (B) He spoke for the White House to NPR.
- ☐ (C) He blocked the Democratic funding attempt.
- ☐ (D) He is the Interior Secretary receiving recommendations.

3. What did administration officials tell historic preservation groups at the Tuesday meeting?

- ☐ (A) The arch had received final federal approval.
- ☐ (B) They would replace the arch with veteran services.
- ☐ (C) They planned to continue with the original arch proposal.
- ☐ (D) The project would move to South Carolina.

4. Which body is widely expected to consider the proposal in early November?

- ☐ (A) The White House
- ☐ (B) The National Capital Planning Commission
- ☐ (C) Public Citizen
- ☐ (D) The Cultural Landscape Foundation

5. What did the Advisory Council on Historic Preservation say it would do by October 7?

- ☐ (A) Hold the midterm elections
- ☐ (B) Give final approval to the arch
- ☐ (C) Build a tarp model
- ☐ (D) Send recommendations directly to Interior Secretary Doug Burgum

6. How could November's midterm elections affect the project?

- ☐ (A) They would guarantee federal funding.
- ☐ (B) They would move the arch away from the bridge.
- ☐ (C) They would automatically end the lawsuit.
- ☐ (D) They could change which party holds power in Congress, potentially affecting the project starting in January.

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: A 3: C 4: B 5: D 6: D

Questions to think about

- 1. Protest speakers:** They questioned the arch's size, cost, location and lack of congressional approval. Several said veterans and their families should have more input.
- 2. Senator Tammy Duckworth and other opponents:** They argued that improving services for veterans would be a better way to honor them.
- 3. The White House:** It told NPR that the arch would improve visits to the cemetery and serve as a reminder of American heroes' sacrifices.
- 4. Administration officials:** They told historic preservation groups that they planned to continue with the original arch proposal.
- 5. Charles Birnbaum of The Cultural Landscape Foundation:** He criticized the decision to end the historic preservation discussions after only two meetings.
- 6. Some protesters:** They hoped Congress would block federal funding for the arch.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):